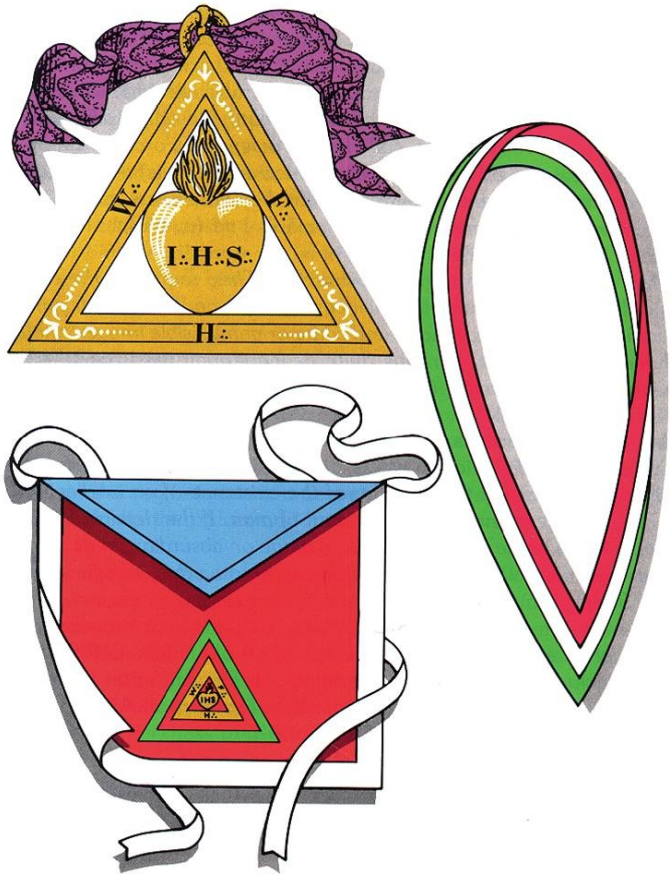
The 26th Degree – Prince of Mercy or Scottish Trinitarian



The apron is scarlet, with a wide border of white. In the center is an equilateral triangle formed of green bars. In the center of this is the jewel, embroidered in gold. The flap is sky–blue. The colors green, red and white symbolize the Masonic Trinity. Green is an emblem of the infinite wisdom; red of the supreme energy, force or power; and white, produced by the mingling of all the colors, of the divine harmony.

The cordon is a broad tri–colored ribbon, green, white and red, worn from right to left.

The jewel is an equilateral triangle, of gold bars, with a flaming heart of gold in the center. On the heart are the letters “I,” “H,” “S”; and on the respective

sides of the triangle “W” on the right, “F” on the left, and “H” at the bottom. This jewel is suspended from a small collar of narrow, watered purple ribbon and hangs on the breast. The last three letters stand for wisdom, force and harmony; the first three are traditional Christian initials for Jesus *Hominum Salvator* (the letters “J” and “I” are interchangeable in Latin) but which may also be read as *Sapientia, Imperium, Harmonia*. Thus, their Masonic meaning is the same meaning as the three upon the bars.

DUTIES

Practice mercy (forgiveness). Be tolerant.
Be devoted to the teaching and diffusion of the true principles of Masonry.

LESSONS

The trinity of Deity belongs to no single religion. The truths of Masonry are contained within the religions of the world.

FOR REFLECTION

“What is truth?” (Pontius Pilate, John 18:38).

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

The numbers 3 and 9, triple interlaced triangle (9 pointed star), arrow, tessera or mark, the colors red, green and white.

In the old rituals this degree was also called Scottish Trinitarian. This older version was heavily modified by Pike who reduced the emphasis on the Old Testament and Hermetic philosophy, expecting its recipients to study the *Legenda*. Although criticized by some for the modifications he made in the old rituals, Pike’s changes were welcomed by Albert Mackey as an improvement and resulted in an enticing degree.

The Mysteries studied thus far have not addressed Christianity. History informs us that the early Christians also disseminated their great truths through initiation in stages or degrees. They were forced to hold meetings and initiations in private places surrounded by great secrecy. We know that the labyrinth of catacombs under Rome provided a place for conveying these Christian Mysteries

to the worthy. The catacombs are underground passages and galleries, probably resulting from the excavation of rock for building. They were also used for burial tombs.

Three classes of initiates existed: the first, the Auditors, were novices who were instructed in the dogma of Christianity; the second, the Catechumens, received baptism; and the third, the Faithful, were taught the profound Mysteries, such as the nativity, passion and resurrection of Christ, in a celebration called the Mass of the Faithful.

The candidate represents a Catechumen who seeks to become one of the Faithful. He assumes the name Constans; which means “constant, steady, faithful, resolute.” History also provides us with additional information to better understand this degree. Constans was the name of the Roman emperor from 337 to 350 A.D. and an ardent Christian. Unlike his father Constantine the Great, Constans was a vigorous opponent of Arianism, a sect of Christianity which questioned the divinity of Christ. Constans supported the Nicene Creed developed in 325 A.D. which recognized as official doctrine the belief that Christ was the Son of God and fully divine. It also propounded the concept of the Trinity in Christianity. This historical parallel is not intended to suggest those not of the Christian faith should exclude themselves from this degree, for its purpose is to teach the universality of many of the doctrines and beliefs of Christianity. The Christian can only have his faith strengthened by knowledge of the ancient wisdom contained in Christianity. The non–Christian should desire knowledge of other faiths and what they teach; from such knowledge comes toleration and understanding.

CEREMONY

The set is a representation of the catacombs under Rome. The hangings are green and are supported by nine columns alternately white and red, as seen in the 9th and 13th degrees. Each column holds a chandelier with three lights. A throne in the East is covered with a canopy of green, white and red. Over the throne is a triple interlaced triangle of these three colors, which in outline forms a nine–

pointed star, in the center of which are the Sanskrit characters equivalent to A, U and M in the Roman alphabet.

The altar is triangular in shape, each side measuring 18 inches, its height 36 inches. Near the altar is a statuette of white marble, covered by a veil of white gauze, described as the palladium of the Order. A palladium is anything believed to provide protection or safety. The most famous was that of Pallas Athene on the citadel of the ancient city of Troy upon which the safety of the city was believed to depend.

“Chief Prince” is the title of the presiding officer. He wears a tunic of green, white and red and a crown of nine points. Other members wear a white tunic and a broad ribbon of green, white and red.

The Chapter has gathered in the catacombs. The candidate, representing Constans and dressed in a plain black robe, seeks entrance that he may be initiated into the last degree of the Christian Mysteries and become one of the Faithful. External cleanliness alone is not acceptable, he must also present himself with a pure soul. The act of washing the hands (symbolic of ethical and moral purity) may remind us of Psalms 24:3–4, “Who shall ascend into the hill of the LORD? Or who shall stand in his holy place? He that hath clean hands and a pure heart;...” Here we should reflect on the similarity of meaning between the act of washing the hands and the white gloves in the 14th Degree. Pontius Pilate sought to relieve himself of responsibility for the death of Christ by the mere outward sign of washing his hands, a fruitless gesture.

In ancient times devotees of faith traditions were often able to see correspondences between the doctrines. In this regard, comparative religion may likewise help us understand that others metaphorically clothe the truth with symbols we may appreciate, however much our personal beliefs may vary.

The ancient Aryans of central Asia recognized Agni who has a threefold being. He is the fire; Indra, the light, and Vishnu, the generator or perpetuator, all are in him and he in them.

The Hindus of India believe in the *Trimurti,* three persons that form one essence: *Brahma*, the creator, *Vishnu,* the perpetuator and *Shiva*, the destroyer.

Each is first and each last in place, neither above, and each first, second and third. The One can be conceived only by the mind and is the source of all intellect, all light and all life.

The ancient Buddhists tell us that above all existences is the Spirit, universal, indestructible, from whom flow the *Buddhas*, each a trinity of intelligence, law and unison and each a redeemer.

Ahura Mazda, said the early Persians, is the Creator and Author of all things. In Him abides the intellect which reveals itself in the universe as action and in men as human intellect. Existing within *Ahura Mazda* are *Spenta Mainyu* and *Vohumano*, the source of life, light and the pure intellect.

The ancient Sabaens of eastern Arabia recognized *Mithra* as the Grand Artificer of the universe, the Spirit of the sun and Light and the Eye of *Ahura Mazda*. He is three in one for his essence illuminates, warms and makes fruitful.

The ancient Scandinavians envisioned a supreme god named *Alfader* (All Father) who is eternal and the Creator who gave immortal souls to man. *Odin, Frea* and their son, *Thor,* are the trinity of the Scandinavian gods.

To the Hermetics of ancient Egypt there was one god, *Amun*, in whom were *Kneph*, the creative intellect, and *Khem*, the Divine generative power. Amun, the concealed God, was believed to act and manifest Himself in *Khem* as the sun and in *Kneph* as the soul of the universe from which all individual souls are emanations.

The Hebrew Kabbalists tell us that *Ainsoph* is the Supreme Who has three heads in one, the three all one within the other. *Kether* is the Divine will; Hakemah is the Divine wisdom; and *Binah* is the Divine intellect.

In the first Epistle of John, it is said that the ancient Christians professed that there are three in heaven: the Father, the Word and the Holy Spirit.

The candidate progression affirms his sincere desire to attain the truth so that he may better perform his duties toward God and man, and vouches for him as one who is true, honest, moral, forgiving of injuries, modest, loving, self–denying, thoughtful, sincere, faithful and as one who would be loyal to the just

cause in the face of danger. He should be careful not to bring shame upon any who vouch for his character.

Having been sufficiently assured of the candidate's sincerity and character, the doctrine that is presumed to have been that which was divulged in the last degree of the Christian Mysteries is presented: the belief in the resurrection.

Parallels are drawn between the slaying of Hiram and the death of Jesus. The malignant priests, wishing to silence Jesus, incited the populace to demand the execution of the friend and benefactor of mankind; in the story of Hiram the first assassin, who struck on the throat, is representative of the priests and the rule he used represents the priesthood. Jesus was likened to a king by Pontius Pilate and the priests said "we have no king but Caesar." The second assassin uses the square, symbolic of despotism, to strike at the heart, the birthplace of all gentle and loving affections. The general populace chose not to release Jesus, but another; they and the setting maul, which struck at the seat of the intellect, are symbolic of that brutal ignorance which causes humanity to hate learning and the enlightened mind.

Additional instruction on the symbolism of the first three degrees in Masonry associates Christian doctrine with Masonry. The three columns of the Masonic temple: Wisdom, Strength and Beauty are typified in the characters of King Solomon, King Hiram and the Master Hiram. They also, by their number, remind us of the Christian Trinity: the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit. The Master's Word symbolizes the new religion, the New Law of Love, brought to the world by Jesus. The true Prince of Mercy obeys the New Law of Love taught in the 18th Degree. He imitates the mercy, goodness and beneficence of God the Father in heaven.

The instruction on the Trinity and the parallels between the symbolism of Christ and Hiram prepare the candidate for the obligation. With the point of an arrow pressed at his temple, he is obligated to be merciful and tolerant and obey this new commandment by loving his brothers. You may recall toleration was a duty in the 18th Degree. Its inclusion here is a testament to its importance. Our Masonic brothers will respect our faith as they have a right to make a similar

demand upon us. The universality of Masonry, its mission to unite all men under virtue, and the truths it teaches demand that each man be accepted for himself and not because of an accident of birth which caused him to be Moslem, Jew or Christian. The truths of Masonry are contained within the religions of the world. Whatever faith a man has, these truths may be embraced by him while he practices his own religion.

The final symbolic actions serve as marks, or tokens, of the solemn covenants entered into by the newly raised Prince of Mercy with the Masonic fraternity, the Deity and truth. After water is poured on the candidate's head as a symbol of the soul's purification, a Tau cross is marked upon his forehead with perfumed oil. The Tau cross has long been an important symbol to the ancients; the Hebrews recognized it as a sign of salvation. In Biblical accounts it was the mark put on the forehead to distinguish those who lamented sin in their midst and would be saved when the idolaters were slain (Ezekiel 4:4). Here, it is a symbol that we are set apart and dedicated to the cause of truth. As the tau cross is marked on the candidate's forehead, the statue near the altar is unveiled. We behold, not an idol to be worshiped, but truth and purity represented as the figure of a virgin holding in her right hand a silver arrow with feathers of red and green and a point of gold. The arrow symbolizes divine justice, a concept closely related to truth; the colors on the arrow are those of this degree and symbolically convey the nature of truth infinite wisdom, supreme force or power and divine harmony. These colors will be seen again, and explained further, in the 28th Degree.

The candidate, along with the other brethren, partakes of bread and wine. These symbols of faith and virtue are not an irreverent imitation of the rites of any church but are a mark of the covenant among the brethren and with God. It should remind us of the brotherhood of every Mason in the world and that reliance on God's loving kindness exalts the soul.

As the third proof of the covenant, the candidate is presented with a tessera or mark in the shape of a fish. The early Christians carried a similar tessera as a mark of their religious beliefs. It was also exchanged as a pledge of friendship and to break the tessera indicated a dissolution of friendship. In Masonry this

token of the covenant of brotherhood is to be kept by its recipient; it may be used to indicate a loan from one brother to another, being kept by the lender until the loan is repaid.

LECTURE

The 26th Degree lecture opens by again stressing the need for toleration in Masonry; allowing each to interpret the symbols and teachings of the degree for himself. Pike says:

> *We utter no word that can be deemed irreverent by any one of any faith. ...Masonry disbelieves no truth, and teaches unbelief in no creed, except so far as such creed may lower its lofty estimate of the Deity, degrade Him to the level of the passions of humanity, deny the high destiny of man, impugn the goodness and benevolence of the Supreme God, ...or inculcate immorality, and disregard of the active duties of the Order* (pp. 524–525).

The lecture continues the emphasis on the concept of the Trinity explored in the ritual. We learn that the three columns of the lodge—Wisdom, Strength and Beauty—symbolize the attributes of God. They may also be seen as symbols of Faith, Hope and Charity, which are the virtues of man. These three virtues are expanded into what Pike calls the Masonic Creed, a concept of Trinity which brings to mind the Nicene Creed of Christianity discussed in the ceremony section:

> *And if men were all Masons, and obeyed with all their heart her mild and gentle teachings, that world would be a paradise; while intolerance and persecution make of it a hell. For this is the Masonic Creed: BELIEVE, in God's Infinite Benevolence, Wisdom, and Justice: HOPE, for the final triumph of Good over Evil, and for Perfect Harmony as the final result of all the concords and discords of the Universe: and be CHARITABLE as God is, toward the unfaith, the errors, the follies, and the faults of men: for all make one great brotherhood* (p. 531).

In the *Legenda* and *Morals and Dogma* we learn of the Triple Covenant of

Mercy which God made with man. The first is that made with Noah when He said, “I will not again curse the earth anymore for man’s sake, neither will I smite everything living as I have done. ...I will establish my covenant with you, and with your seed after you, and with every living creature. ...I do set my bow in the cloud and it shall be for a token of a covenant between me and the earth” (selections from Genesis 8:21–9:13). The second covenant is the one made by God with Abraham when He instituted the rite of circumcision by which God promised that Abraham would be the father of many nations. The third covenant is that which God made with all men by His prophets: that He would gather all nations and tongues and they shall see His glory and that His Spirit and His Word should remain with men forever and to mankind he gave Jesus.

The covenant tradition in the Bible is a long and varied one. Of particular note is that several words in Hebrew have all been translated into English using only the word “covenant”; but several vases exist where the meaning of the Hebrew word is actually brotherhood,” “law” and, on occasion, “word.” The three discussed here are covenants in which God is bound in perpetuity and a “sign” or token of the covenant is given. “Covenant” implies far more than an oath. These express the nature of the relationship between God and his community. In becoming a Prince of Mercy, we enter into solemn covenant with the Masonic fraternity.

Couched within a catechism are what Pike called the “nine Great Truths of Masonry.” As the 26th Degree closes the series of degrees that illustrate the Mysteries, these Truths appropriately summarize the teachings from the 23rd through the 26th Degrees.

1. No man has seen God at any time; that is, God is only spiritual.
2. The soul of man is immortal.
3. The Moral Sense of man derives from God and therefore has a divine source and is a divine imperative.
4. Moral truths are as real as physical truths. They are not created by God but are a part of His nature; therefore morality is not an arbitrary law of

God but a part of that goodness which constitutes His essence.

5. The distinction between good and evil is essential. Having the ability to make the distinction is a unique quality of man whose ability to do good is only made meaningful by his ability to do that which s not good.
6. There are no degrees in the practice of moral obligations; it s neither variable nor contingent. No excuse can justify one's failure to exercise the moral imperatives of a just life.
7. The immutable law of God requires, that besides respecting he absolute rights of others, and being just, we should do good, be charitable, and obey the dictates of the generous and noble sentiments of the soul. We are but the almoners of God's riches and thus charity can know neither rule nor limit. It is the most sacred of all Masonic obligations.
8. The laws which control and regulate the universe are those of motion and harmony. Evil is merely apparent, and all is in reality good and perfect. The existence of misfortune and adversity provides the opportunity for the expression of those virtues which ennoble the soul and elevate the spirit of man; thus is the evil of this world but part of the great plan of God for the betterment of man.
9. The last Great Truth of Masonry is the paradox of the equipoise of the infinite justice and infinite mercy of God; the former alone would call for man's utter destruction, the latter alone would permit the most offensive hedonism. Together they provide man with both retribution and forgiveness.

A large portion of the lecture is also devoted to the Trinity and its manifestation in the major faiths. It provides a wealth of detail to substantiate the near universality of the concept of the Trinity and emphasizes the development of the beliefs of various Gnostic schools. We are urged to return to the simple and sublime creed of Masonry:

It is useless to trace these vagaries further; and we stop at the frontiers of the realm of the three hundred and sixty–five thousand emanations of the Mandaites from the Primitive Light, Fira or Ferho and Yavar; and return contentedly to the simple and sublime creed of Masonry.

Such were some of the ancient notions concerning the Deity; and taken in connection with what has been detailed in the preceding Degrees, this Lecture affords you a true picture of the ancient speculations. From the beginning until now, those who have undertaken to solve the great mystery of the creation of a material universe by an Immaterial Deity, have interposed between the two, and between God and man, divers manifestations of, or emanations from, or personified attributes or agents of, the Great Supreme God, who is coexistent with Time and coextensive with Space (p. 568).

The creed of Masonry developed from the ancients emphasizes the nature of Deity, the nature of man and the relationship between the Deity and man. The following selections from the lecture summarize in simple language the lessons of the Mystery Degrees. Taken as a whole, we learn the simple and sublime creed of Masonry.

The Creed of Masonry:

God, therefore, is a mystery, only as everything that surrounds us, and as we ourselves, are mysteries. ...This is the real idea of the Ancient Nations: GOD, the Almighty Father, and Source of All; His THOUGHT, conceiving the whole Universe, and willing its creation; His WORD, uttering that THOUGHT, and thus becoming the Creator... in whom was Life and Light, and that Light the Life of the Universe. ...

Nor did that Word cease at the single act of Creation; .... FOR THE THOUGHT OF GOD LIVES AND IS IMMORTAL. Embodied in the Word, is not only created, but it preserves. ..Behold THE TRUE MASONIC TRINITY; the UNIVERSAL SOUL, the THOUGHT in the Soul, the WORD, or Thought expressed; the THREE IN ONE, of a Trinitarian Ecossais (pp. 574–575).

While all these faiths assert their claims to the exclusive possession of the Truth, Masonry inculcates its old doctrine, and no more: .... That God is ONE; that His THOUGHT uttered in His WORD, created the Universe, and preserves it by those Eternal Laws which are the expression of that Thought; that the Soul of Man, breathed into him by God, is immortal as His Thoughts are; that he is free to do evil or to choose good, responsible for his acts and punishable for his sins; that all evil and wrong and suffering are but temporary, the discords of one great Harmony, and that in His good time they will lead by infinite modulations to the great, harmonic final chord and cadence of Truth, Love, Peace, and Happiness, that will reign forever and ever under the Arches of Heaven, among all the Stars and Worlds, and in all souls of men and Angels (pp. 576–77).